

EVERYDAY MILLIONAIRE

Cliff came from a huge family—he’s the oldest of ten children—and he remembers money always being tight as a kid. He said they always had food on the table, but there was never any extra money. That meant he was on his own when it came time for college. He worked his tail off to put himself through school, and he ultimately graduated with a double major. Cliff got a great job with an oil company right out of college, and he impressed his bosses and coworkers with his intelligence and stamina for long, hard days of work. The company promoted him every few years, and he eventually retired from there as the vice president in charge of global purchasing.

Throughout his career, Cliff and his amazing wife of fifty-eight years prioritized saving. He was used to living on little, and he never let his promotions or rising salary go to his head. Each raise meant more money to save. Sure, they enjoyed their life and never lacked anything they really wanted, but they were never interested in spending for the sake of spending. He taught himself the basics of investing early in his career and put systems in place for regular savings. Starting early, he said, was one of the big reasons for his wealth today. He invested whatever he could every step of his career, and he watched his investment portfolio grow year after year.

Cliff admits that he fell for some debt traps early in his adult life, but those days are far behind him. When we asked what advice he’d give future millionaires, he broke it down into two easy steps: “Get debt-free as soon as possible and have a plan for investing to be able to achieve what you want to do.” For Cliff, “what you want to do” means being able to do *what* he wants *when* he wants. That’s freedom in action. He and his wife, now worth \$6.7 million, are enjoying an active life of traveling, fishing, and golf. That may not be *your* retirement dream, but it’s theirs—and they did whatever it took to make that dream happen.

Financial Independence vs. Financial Dependence

Whenever I hear someone say they want to be rich, I know what they’re *really* saying is that they want all the things wealth enables you to do. Like I’ve said, financial independence means freedom, and freedom is something we all want. When it comes to financial independence, I think we’re basically talking about four things:

1. *Flexibility.* This comes down to freedom of time. You’re not punching a time clock, and no boss is looking over your shoulder.